

BONUS 5 OF 5

Yarn Guide & Shopping List

Which yarn for each size, how much to buy, the right hook and a no-waste shopping list.

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SECTION 1

Yarn Types for Backpacks

Know exactly which yarn to grab for structured bags, soft pouches, and everything in between.

Not every yarn works for bags. Backpacks need structure, durability and a clean stitch definition that lighter yarns simply cannot provide. This section covers the five yarn families you will use most.

The Five Yarn Families

YARN TYPE	BEST FOR	PROS	CONS
T-shirt yarn	Structured bags, large backpacks, market totes	Extremely sturdy; holds its shape without lining; wide color range; recycled material	Heavy; limited stitch definition on textured patterns; can stretch over time if bag is overloaded
Cotton cord (3–5 mm)	Medium and small backpacks, drawstring bags	Clean stitch definition; machine washable; lightweight compared to t-shirt yarn; matte finish	Less structure than t-shirt yarn; may need a fabric lining for larger sizes
Acrylic (worsted/bulky)	Kids' backpacks, colorwork, budget-friendly projects	Affordable; huge color selection; easy care; lightweight; great for appliques	Less rigid; always needs a lining for structure; can pill with heavy use
Wool blend (50/50 or superwash)	Cold-weather bags, felted backpacks	Natural elasticity; beautiful drape; can be felted for extra stiffness; warm to touch	Higher cost; needs careful washing; may felt unintentionally; not ideal for hot climates
Raffia / paper yarn	Summer bags, beach backpacks, boho style	Natural texture; very lightweight; stiffens on its own after blocking; unique look	Not machine washable; can split while crocheting; limited color palette

Quick Decision Guide

- 1 Ask yourself: will this bag carry weight daily?** — If yes, choose t-shirt yarn or cotton cord (3–5 mm). They hold shape under load without extra reinforcement.
- 2 Is the bag for a child or for decoration?** — Acrylic is lighter, cheaper and comes in every color imaginable. Perfect for kids’ character backpacks and novelty designs.
- 3 Do you want a seasonal / artisan look?** — Raffia for summer, wool blend for winter. Both create a distinctive texture that cotton and acrylic cannot replicate.

Pro Tip

If you are new to bag-making, start with cotton cord in 3 mm. It is forgiving, easy to frog (undo), and produces a clean, professional finish on your first try.

Common Mistake

Avoid using thin, drapey yarns (lace weight, fingering, baby yarn) for backpacks. They produce a fabric that sags under any weight, no matter how tight your tension is.

Yarn Weight Reference

WEIGHT CATEGORY	THICKNESS	TYPICAL USE IN BACKPACKS
Bulky (5)	5–7 mm	Body of structured bags, straps on large packs
Super Bulky (6)	7–10 mm	T-shirt yarn bags, chunky market totes
Worsted (4)	4–5 mm	Kids’ bags, colorwork panels, appliques
DK / Light Worsted (3)	3–4 mm	Small pouches, phone bags, coin purses

SECTION 2

How Much Yarn Do You Need?

Buy the right amount the first time — no mid-project panic runs, no leftover waste.

Running out of yarn mid-project (especially from a dyed lot) means a visible color shift in your finished bag. Buying too much wastes money. Use the tables below as your planning guide.

Yarn Amounts by Backpack Size

Estimates assume a single-color body worked in single crochet with cotton cord or t-shirt yarn. Colorwork, textured stitches, and straps may add 10–20% more.

BACKPACK SIZE	APPROXIMATE DIMENSIONS	COTTON CORD (3 MM)	T-SHIRT YARN	ACRYLIC WORSTED
Mini	15 × 12 × 6 cm	120–150 g / 180–220 m	200–250 g / 50–65 m	100–130 g / 200–260 m
Small	22 × 18 × 8 cm	200–250 g / 300–370 m	350–450 g / 90–115 m	180–220 g / 360–440 m
Medium	30 × 25 × 12 cm	350–420 g / 520–630 m	600–750 g / 155–190 m	280–340 g / 560–680 m
Large	38 × 30 × 15 cm	500–600 g / 750–900 m	900–1100 g / 230–280 m	400–480 g / 800–960 m

The 20% Rule

Always buy at least 20% more yarn than the estimate. This covers gauge differences, stitch pattern variations and the inevitable “oops, I frogged three rows.” Leftover yarn makes great keychains or zipper pulls.

How to Calculate for a Custom Size

- 1 Crochet a 10 × 10 cm swatch** — Use the same yarn weight, hook size and stitch pattern you plan to use. Measure the yarn consumed (weigh the ball before and after).
- 2 Calculate your bag’s surface area** — Add up front panel + back panel + two side panels + bottom + flap. For a cylinder-shaped bag, use circumference × height + base circle.

- 3 Multiply** — $(\text{Surface area in cm}^2) \div 100 \times (\text{grams used for the } 10 \times 10 \text{ cm swatch}) = \text{total grams needed for the body.}$
- 4 Add extras** — Straps: add 15–20% of body weight. Flap/closure: add 10%. Colorwork or textured stitch: add 10–15% more on top.

Dye Lot Warning

If you are buying multiple skeins, check that all skeins share the same dye lot number on the label. Different lots may look identical in the store but show a visible stripe once crocheted together.

Strap Yarn Add-On

STRAP STYLE	LENGTH	EXTRA YARN (COTTON CORD)	EXTRA YARN (T-SHIRT)
Single shoulder strap	60–80 cm	40–55 g	70–100 g
Two backpack straps	50–70 cm each	70–100 g	120–180 g
Drawstring cord	100–120 cm	25–35 g	45–60 g
Crossbody strap	100–130 cm	55–75 g	90–130 g

SECTION 3

Choosing the Right Hook

The right hook turns frustrating tension into effortless stitches.

Your hook does two jobs: it controls stitch size (gauge) and it determines how comfortable you are while working. Both matter for a project that takes several hours.

Hook Size by Yarn Weight

YARN WEIGHT	RECOMMENDED HOOK (MM)	US LETTER SIZE	NOTES FOR BAGS
DK / Light Worsted (3)	3.5–4.5	E/4 – 7	Go down 0.5 mm from label for a tighter, sturdier fabric
Worsted (4)	4.5–5.5	7 – I/9	Standard for kids' bags and colorwork panels
Bulky (5)	6.0–7.0	J/10 – K/10.5	Good balance of speed and structure
Super Bulky (6) / T-shirt yarn	8.0–12.0	L/11 – P/16	Use the lower end for tighter, bag-ready fabric
Raffia / paper yarn	5.0–7.0	H/8 – K/10.5	Depends on strand thickness; do a swatch first

Bags Need Tight Fabric

For backpacks, use a hook 0.5–1.0 mm *smaller* than the yarn label suggests. You want a dense fabric that does not stretch or show gaps when the bag is loaded. If you can see daylight through your swatch, go down a size.

Hook Material Comparison

Aluminum

Smooth, fast, affordable. Yarn glides easily. Best all-around choice for cotton cord and acrylic. Can feel cold in winter.

Steel

Very small sizes only (0.5–3.0 mm). Used for thread crochet and fine detail work. Not typically needed for backpacks.

Bamboo / Wood

Warm, lightweight, gentle on hands. Slightly grippy surface prevents slippery yarns from escaping. Great for raffia and wool blends.

Ergonomic (rubber grip)

Aluminum or plastic shaft with a padded handle. Reduces hand fatigue on long sessions. Highly recommended if you crochet for more than an hour at a time.

How to Test Your Gauge

- 1 Chain 15 and work 12 rows of single crochet** — This gives you a test swatch slightly larger than 10 × 10 cm.
- 2 Lay it flat without stretching** — Place a ruler horizontally across the middle and count how many stitches fit in 10 cm.
- 3 Compare to the pattern gauge** — If you have more stitches than the pattern says, your tension is too tight (go up a hook size). Fewer stitches = too loose (go down).
- 4 For bags, aim for the tight end** — If the pattern says 12–14 stitches per 10 cm, target 14. A denser fabric holds up better under daily use.

Don't Skip the Swatch

It takes five minutes and saves you from frogging an entire bag panel. Different hook materials can change your gauge even at the same mm size, because the surface friction varies.

SECTION 4

Essential Hardware Shopping List

Every clasp, ring and fastener your backpacks need — nothing missing, nothing extra.

Hardware turns a crocheted pouch into a functional backpack. The items below cover closures, strap adjusters, and finishing tools. Buy them before you start so you do not have to pause mid-project.

Closures & Fasteners

ITEM	COMMON SIZES	WHAT IT DOES	HOW MANY TO BUY
Magnetic snap	14 mm / 18 mm	Hidden closure for flaps. Clicks shut magnetically.	1 per backpack flap
Turn lock (twist clasp)	25 × 18 mm / 30 × 20 mm	Decorative front closure. Turns 90° to lock.	1 per bag (alternative to magnetic snap)
Zipper	15 cm / 20 cm / 25 cm	Main compartment or inner pocket closure.	1–2 per bag depending on design
Buttons (shank style)	15–25 mm	Loop-and-button closure for casual designs.	1–2 per bag
Drawstring stopper	one-hole / two-hole	Locks a drawstring cord in place.	1–2 per drawstring bag

Rings & Adjusters

ITEM	COMMON SIZES	WHAT IT DOES	HOW MANY TO BUY
D-ring	20 mm / 25 mm / 32 mm	Connects straps to the bag body. Essential for adjustable straps.	2–4 per backpack
Swivel snap hook	20 mm / 25 mm	Clip-on attachment for removable straps.	2 per removable strap
Slide adjuster (tri-glide)	20 mm / 25 mm	Lets you shorten or lengthen a strap. Thread the strap through to adjust.	2 per pair of backpack straps
O-ring	20 mm / 30 mm	Decorative connector or keychain anchor point.	1–2 as needed

Finishing Tools

Tools Checklist

- ☐ Yarn needle (blunt tip, large eye) — for weaving in ends and sewing pieces together
- ☐ Stitch markers (locking style) — at least 10; mark round starts and pattern repeats
- ☐ Measuring tape (flexible, cm + inches) — check dimensions as you go
- ☐ Sharp scissors — for clean yarn cuts; dull scissors fray the ends
- ☐ Fabric glue or fray check — secure knots on hardware attachments
- ☐ Sewing needle + matching thread — for attaching zippers and lining fabric
- ☐ Pins (sewing pins or wonder clips) — hold pieces in place while joining
- ☐ Row counter (manual or app) — track your progress on long panels

Match Your Metal

Pick one finish for all hardware on a single bag — all gold, all silver, or all antique brass. Mixing finishes looks unintentional and distracts from the crochet work.

Check the Inner Width

When buying D-rings, snap hooks and slide adjusters, make sure the inner width matches your strap width. A 25 mm D-ring will not fit a strap crocheted at 30 mm wide.

SECTION 5

Color Planning

Pick 2–3 colors that look intentional and professional every time.

You do not need to study color theory for a semester. A simple method based on three relationships will give you combinations that always work together.

Three Safe Color Strategies

1. Monochrome

What it is: One color in two or three shades (light, medium, dark).

Example: Dusty rose body + blush flap + burgundy straps.

Best for: Elegant, minimalist bags. Hard to get wrong.

2. Neutral + One Pop

What it is: A neutral base (cream, gray, black, beige) plus one bold accent color.

Example: Cream body + mustard flap and trim.

Best for: Modern, versatile bags that match many outfits.

3. Complementary Pair

What it is: Two colors from opposite sides of the color wheel, with one used sparingly.

Example: Navy body + terracotta details (about 80/20 ratio).

Best for: Eye-catching designs that still feel balanced.

Bonus: Earth Tones

What it is: Any mix of browns, tans, olive, terracotta and cream.

Example: Taupe body + olive straps + cream drawstring.

Best for: Boho and nature-inspired backpacks. Almost impossible to clash.

Step-by-Step: Pick Your Palette

- 1 Choose your main color** — This is the body of the bag and uses about 60–70% of your total yarn. Pick a color you will enjoy looking at for several hours of work.
- 2 Choose a contrast color** — Used for the flap, trim, straps or decorative rows. It should be clearly different from the main color — either lighter, darker, or a different hue.

- 3 **Optional: add an accent** — A small amount (5–10%) of a third color for edging, buttons, or a single stripe. Keep this one bold if the other two are neutral.
- 4 **Test before you commit** — Wind a short length of each yarn around a piece of cardboard, side by side. Look at them in natural daylight, not just store lighting.

Colors That Cause Problems

Neon and fluorescent yarns fade faster, bleed during washing, and are harder to photograph if you plan to sell your bags. Stick with saturated (non-neon) colors for durability.

Color Proportion Guide

NUMBER OF COLORS	RECOMMENDED RATIO	WHERE EACH GOES
1 color	100%	Entire bag — texture and hardware provide visual interest
2 colors	70 / 30	Main = body + straps. Secondary = flap + border
3 colors	60 / 30 / 10	Main = body. Secondary = flap + straps. Accent = edging or one stripe

SECTION 6

Your First Shopping List

Everything you need for your first crochet backpack — one page, ready to take to the store.

This checklist is designed for a beginner making a small-to-medium backpack in cotton cord. Tear it out (or screenshot it) and take it with you when you shop.

Yarn

- ☐ Cotton cord, 3 mm — main color: 3 skeins (approx. 300–400 g total)
- ☐ Cotton cord, 3 mm — contrast color: 1 skein (approx. 100–130 g)
- ☐ Confirm all skeins of the same color share one dye lot number

Hooks & Tools

- ☐ Crochet hook — 4.0 mm (start here; go down to 3.5 mm if your swatch is too loose)
- ☐ Crochet hook — 3.5 mm (backup / tight-fabric option)
- ☐ Yarn needle, blunt tip, large eye — 1
- ☐ Locking stitch markers — pack of 10 or more
- ☐ Flexible measuring tape
- ☐ Sharp scissors
- ☐ Row counter (optional but helpful)

Hardware

- ☐ D-rings, 25 mm, matching finish — 4 pieces
- ☐ Slide adjusters (tri-glide), 25 mm, same finish — 2 pieces
- ☐ Magnetic snap, 18 mm — 1 set (two halves)
- ☐ Zipper, 20 cm, color-matched to main yarn — 1 (for inner pocket)

Finishing & Assembly

- ☐ Sewing needle + thread (matching main color) — for zipper and lining
- ☐ Wonder clips or sewing pins — at least 6
- ☐ Fabric glue or fray check — 1 small bottle
- ☐ Lining fabric (cotton canvas or quilting cotton), approx. 50 × 40 cm — optional but recommended

Budget Tip

You do not need everything on day one. Start with yarn, one hook, a yarn needle, and stitch markers. You can buy the hardware and lining supplies when you reach the assembly stage of the pattern.

Shopping Notes

- 1 Touch before you buy** — If shopping in person, squeeze the skein. For bags, you want a yarn that feels firm, not squishy. A firm yarn produces a structured fabric.
- 2 Read the label** — Check fiber content (100% cotton for cotton cord), yardage per skein, and care instructions. Write down the dye lot number in case you need to buy more later.
- 3 Buy one extra skein of the main color** — If the store has it in the same dye lot, grab one more. You can always return an unopened skein, but you cannot always find the same lot again.
- 4 Save your receipts and labels** — Keep yarn labels in a small zip bag. They contain the dye lot, fiber content, and care symbols you will need when washing the finished bag.

SECTION 7

Storage & Care Tips

Keep your yarn organized and your finished backpacks looking new for years.

Good storage protects your investment (yarn is not cheap) and proper washing keeps your finished backpacks in gift-ready condition.

Storing Yarn

Do

- Store in a cool, dry place away from direct sunlight (UV fades colors)
- Use clear bins or zip bags so you can see what you have
- Add a cedar block or lavender sachet to deter moths (especially for wool blends)
- Keep yarn labels with their skeins (rubber band around the label works)
- Wind loose hanks into cakes or balls before storing — they take up less space and do not tangle

Don't

- Store in damp basements or garages — moisture causes mildew
- Leave skeins loose in a bag — they tangle and attract dust
- Stack heavy items on top of yarn bins — crushes the fiber and changes texture
- Mix mothballs with yarn — the chemical smell transfers to the fiber permanently

Washing Finished Backpacks

YARN TYPE	WASH METHOD	DRYING	SPECIAL NOTES
Cotton cord	Machine wash, cold, gentle cycle (inside a pillowcase or mesh bag)	Reshape while damp, air dry flat	May shrink slightly on first wash; pre-wash yarn if concerned
T-shirt yarn	Machine wash, cold, gentle cycle	Air dry flat or hang by the straps	Stretches when wet — do not wring; squeeze water out gently
Acrylic	Machine wash, warm or cold, normal cycle	Tumble dry low or air dry	Most forgiving — holds up well to repeated washing

YARN TYPE	WASH METHOD	DRYING	SPECIAL NOTES
Wool blend	Hand wash only in lukewarm water with gentle soap	Roll in a towel to remove excess water, air dry flat	Hot water or agitation causes felting (intentional felting is a different process)
Raffia / paper	Spot clean only with a damp cloth	Air dry completely before storing	Water weakens the fibers — never submerge

Between Washes

For daily maintenance, turn the bag inside out and shake it to remove crumbs and dust. A lint roller picks up pet hair from the surface without stressing the stitches.

Keeping the Shape

- 1 Stuff when not in use** — Fill the bag with tissue paper or a folded towel to maintain its shape during storage. Do not use newspaper (the ink transfers).
- 2 Remove hardware before washing** — If the bag has removable straps or clip-on accessories, take them off. Metal can snag stitches in the machine.
- 3 Block after washing** — Lay the damp bag on a flat surface, gently shape it to the correct dimensions, and pin if necessary. Let it dry completely.
- 4 Store upright or hanging** — If the bag has structure, store it upright on a shelf (like a book). Soft bags can hang from a hook by their straps.

Iron with Caution

Never press a hot iron directly on crochet — it flattens the texture and can melt acrylic fibers. If you need to smooth a seam, use a steamer held 5–10 cm away or press through a damp cloth on the lowest setting.

Next Step

Open the main pattern collection, pick your first backpack design, and use the shopping list from Section 6 to gather your supplies. Your first bag is one swatch away.